a secret even from the Assam government, this was the only region where the Tibetans were exercising control on a non-Tibetan population across the watershed. Perhaps with this in mind, the British decided to raise an additional Assam Rifles battalion, which came into being in June 1920 at Lokhra. Along with 2 Assam Rifles, 5 Assam Rifles would be the other unit destined to play a major role in the events to come.

The new battalion's Area of Responsibility (AOR) included the Kamrup and Darrang borders that faced Aka and Dafla dominated areas. The battalion set up posts (all in the plains) facing North Lakhimpur, Harmati, Dikulmakh, Hathipaithi, Udalguri and Darrang. However, around this time other events were to occur that would put any thoughts of venturing out towards Tawang on the back burner. The time between 1920 and 1922 saw a spike in activity in the struggle for independence following British atrocities in Jallianwala Bagh in 1919 and elsewhere. After Mahatma Gandhi moved a resolution at a special session of the Indian National Congress in Calcutta pledging total non-cooperation with the government, Assamese nationalists instigated riots and organized strikes in the tea gardens. The Assam Rifles, including 5 Assam Rifles, was constantly deployed in an attempt to bring the situation under control.

By 1932, as part of the post-war economy drive, 5 Assam Rifles was disbanded and its men transferred to 2 Assam Rifles to form an amalgamated, composite unit comprising two headquarters and eighteen platoons. In the new deployment, only four platoons were left at Lokhra, which was the gateway into the Kameng Sector.

However, shortly thereafter, the Government of India Act of 1935 necessitated a more accurate defining of the tribal areas in Assam. It was now public knowledge that the frontier of India had been wrongly shown on British maps, and that the Tawang salient was indeed a part of British India. The Assam government was quick to act. The political officer from Balipara, Captain G. S. Lightfoot, was ordered to undertake a 'preliminary and exploratory' mission to Tawang. On 12 April 1938, Lightfoot set out from Lokhra with a force of two platoons (200 rifles) under the command of Major W. F. Brown. The column proceeded into the thick jungle-clad hills, moving along the Bhutan border via Doimara, Shergaon and then across the fir-clad slopes of Manda-la into Dirang Dzong. Despite the difficulties created by the dzongpens, they commandeered enough local